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Virendra Saklani/Gulf News

CHRISTMAS IN THE UAE

A family lights candles before attending Christmas eve mass at St Mary's Catholic Church in Dubai yesterday. As the world welcomed the spirit of Christmas, the expat community in the UAE visited churches to attend services to mark the birth of Jesus Christ. Masses were held in several languages, including Arabic, English, Malayalam, Tamil, Urdu, Tagalog, Sinhala, French, Italian, Korean, Spanish, Ukrainian and Polish. **SEE ALSO P3**

UAE bans unauthorised price hikes on nine essential goods

Consumers urged to report violations as part of new policy

DUBAI
BY JUSTIN VARGHESE
Your Money Editor

Starting January 2, the UAE Ministry of Economy will roll out a ban on any unauthorised price increases on cooking oil, eggs, dairy, rice, sugar, poultry, legumes, bread, and wheat, as it looks to protect consumers and promote competition.

The UAE Ministry of Economy said yesterday that it will implement the new pricing policy on nine categories of essential goods, with any price hikes requiring prior approval from the ministry. It added that at least six months are needed between two consecutive increases in prices of these basic goods from next year.

Abdullah Ahmad Al Saleh, Undersecretary of the Ministry of Economy, stated that

**The nine items are:
cooking oil, eggs,
dairy, rice, sugar,
poultry, legumes,
bread, and wheat.**

the new policy aligns with ongoing legislative reforms, including amendments to the Consumer Protection Law and Cabinet guidelines on pricing. These efforts aim to enhance transparency, market stability, and consumer rights.

Report violations

The policy empowers consumers to report violations as it seeks to balance supply and demand, prevent monopolistic practices, and promote sustainable consumption.

A dedicated team will oversee pricing, assess requests for increases, and investigate complaints.

Dubai gears up for New Year celebrations

8,530 Dubai Police officers, 1,145 patrols to be deployed

DUBAI
BY AGHADDIR ALI
Senior Reporter

All preparations are in place to ensure a secure and festive celebration of New Year's Eve in Dubai, with government departments coordinating traffic, parking, safety, public transport and clean-up operations.

Details of the plan were revealed yesterday during a press conference by the Events Security Committee, which said there will be fireworks displays at 36 locations across Dubai.

The main display which attracts more revellers is the one launched from Burj Khalifa, the world's tallest tower. A smooth flow of residents and visitors will be directed by the deployment 8,530 Dubai Police officers and 1,145 patrols, Civil Defence vehicles, with ambulances on standby. Six mobile operations rooms will monitor activities across the emirate.

To prevent bottlenecks, some roads, especially around the Burj Khalifa and Dubai Mall area, will be closed from late afternoon until official festivities end.

In order to meet the high demand for public transport, Dubai Metro (Red and Green lines) will operate continuously for 43 hours from 5am on December 31, 2024 until midnight on January 1, 2025.

Also, more than 200 buses will transport guests to key locations.

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Syria's armed groups agree to disband

MEMBERS OF ALL FACTIONS TO BE INTEGRATED INTO DEFENCE FORCES

DAMASCUS

Syria's new authorities announced yesterday that they had reached an agreement with the country's rebel groups on their dissolution and integration into the regular defence forces.

Photos published by the state-run Sana news agency showed the country's new leader, Ahmad Al Sharaa, surrounded by the heads of several armed factions — but not representatives of the Kurdish-led forces in Syria's northeast.

The meeting "ended in an agreement on the dissolution of all the groups and their integration under the supervision of the ministry of defence", said a statement carried by Sana and the authorities' Telegram account.

On Sunday, Sharaa had said the new authorities would "absolutely not allow there to be weapons in the country outside state control".

That also applied to the Kurdish-led Syrian Democratic Forces, he said.

Last week, the military chief of Sharaa's Hayat Tahrir Al

Sham — the group that spearheaded the offensive that toppled president Bashar Al Assad — told AFP that Kurdish-held areas would be integrated under the new leadership, and that "Syria will not be divided".

Qatar calls for lifting of sanctions

In another development, Qatar yesterday called for the quick removal of sanctions on Syria.

"We call for intensified efforts to expedite the lifting of international sanctions on Syria," foreign ministry spokesperson Majed Al Ansari told a regular briefing.

Qatar's call came a day after a high-level delegation visited Damascus. The Qatari embassy there reopened on Sunday, ending a 13-year rift between the two countries. —AFP

Sharaa said the new authorities would 'absolutely not allow there to be weapons in the country outside state control'.



SPORT

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